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firmly on the Dalai Lama, who he accused of attempting to sabotage the Beijing Olympics. "We have ample evidence to prove that the riots were organized, premeditated, masterminded and incited by the Dalai clique," he said, without substantiating his claim. On one point though, Wen was right: the violent protests that engulfed much of ethnic Tibet last week were undoubtedly Olympics-inspired. The Tibetan monks who sparked the riots chose their moment carefully. Not only was the world media focused on China ahead of the Games but they reasoned Beijing could ill-afford a brutal response that would risk international calls for an Olympic boycott.

The Olympic backdrop presented the perfect opportunity for a Tibetan people ripe for protest. Since the People's Liberation Army wrested control of Tibet in 1950, there have been only two major crackdowns in the Himalayan state. The first, in 1959, saw thousands of Tibetans flee across the border into Nepal and India, led by their spiritual leader the Dalai Lama. Then the second in 1988 was dealt with brutally by the then party secretary of Tibet and current President Hu Jintao.

It is now more than 20 years since Tibetans last protested in numbers against China's continued occupation of their homeland. Since then, the influx of ethnic Chinese into the so-called Tibetan Autonomous Region has continued unabated. Most Tibetans view this as a concerted attempt by Beijing to dilute the Tibetan culture and tighten its grip politically. Nevertheless, the Dalai Lama's accusation that Beijing is guilty of "cultural genocide" is an exaggeration. Since the disastrous excesses of the Cultural Revolution in the 1960s and '70s, Tibetans have been given constricted freedom to worship and to celebrate local traditions. The monasteries, once desecrated and empty, have been rebuilt and are today filled with a new generation of monks.

But many Tibetans find it hard to bear the stifling controls that remain in place. Monks are banned from follow-

ing their religious leader the Dalai Lama and any public hint of wrong thinking is swiftly quashed. Tibetan children know they must study in Mandarin to avoid a life of penury, while adults fear that the essence of Tibetan culture is slowly melting away. The latest bout of riots was therefore a long overdue cultural call-to-arms. Tibetans burned and looted shops owned by ethnic Chinese and beat up passers-by who spoke in Mandarin. That the Tibetan anger should eventually boil over was hardly unexpected.

More politically revealing was the authorities' response, which married the clunky Communist denunciations of yore with a savvy, more media-friendly approach. Wen's blasting of the "Dalai clique" followed the traditional path. It is far more convenient for the Communist leadership to blame agita-

tors abroad for stirring up trouble within China's borders than to admit widespread discontent among its own Tibetan citizens. Beijing's line on the Dalai Lama, who it fears precisely because he commands the loyalty of Tibetans despite possessing no formal political power, is unwavering.

Yet, Beijing has also demonstrated a subtler understanding of how to deal with the situation than it has done before. The local paramilitary forces reportedly showed remarkable restraint by their own standards. Estimates of the number of dead in the riots vary widely from the official toll of 13 to over 70 as claimed by the Tibetan government-in-exile in Dharamshala. But there has so far been little evidence of indiscriminate shooting by the Chinese police, even as Tibetan rioters were setting fire to police cars.

More surprising is that Beijing has allowed an unprecedented amount of domestic reporting. True, the international media has been subjected to all the usual controls. Reports of the rioting in Lhasa carried by BBC and CNN last Friday were blacked out, while foreign press reports have been blocked on the Internet. And some journalists' email accounts were inaccessible for several

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